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CONSUMER PREFERENCE ANALYSIS IN E-COMMERCE PLATFORMS

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ABSTRACT:

The rapid expansion of e-commerce has significantly transformed consumer purchasing behavior across the world. Due to the growth of the internet, smartphones and digital payment systems consumers increasingly prefer online marketplaces for buying products. E-commerce platforms provide customers with the efficiency to browse products compare prices and make purchases at their convenience. This eliminates limitations associated with traditional retail stores. The shift toward shopping has created new opportunities for businesses. It also increases the importance of understanding consumer preferences in environments. A significant factor contributing to e-commerce expansion is the ease and convenience experienced by consumers. Online shopping platforms allow users to access product options without physically visiting stores. Features such as search options, detailed product descriptions and customer feedback assist consumers in making purchasing decisions. Time efficiency is important for shopping. Many people like the speed and ease of platforms compared to traditional retail stores. Online stores often give discounts, seasonal sales and special offers. These deals encourage people to buy products. The ability to easily compare prices on platforms makes it clear what the prices are. This helps people choose the option. As a result pricing and promotions have become factors in online shopping decisions. Trust and security are crucial for shopping. People want to feel safe when making transactions online. Online shopping platforms must focus on trust and security to provide a shopping experience. Online retailers provide discounts and seasonal sales to encourage consumers to purchase products. The online platforms provide the speed and accessibility for consumers to shop. The consumers want to feel secure and have trust when making transactions, on e-commerce platforms. This builds customer loyalty. Drives repeat business.

Keywords: *Consumer preference, E-commerce, Online shopping behavior, Customer satisfaction, Digital platforms, Buying Behavior, Trust and Security, User Experience, Purchase Decision, Pricing Strategies.*

INTRODUCTION

The internet and digital connections have greatly changed retail markets over the past 20 years. With high-speed internet, smartphones and digital payment systems becoming more available people are shopping online more. Moving away from physical stores. Online shopping platforms let customers look, evaluate and buy products and services digitally without being limited by location or store hours.

This change has made businesses more accessible. Increased their market presence with greater convenience in buying. According to studies customers rely more on e-commerce platforms for daily purchases due to convenience and easy product availability online. The COVID-19 pandemic increased digital shopping as people chose buying for safety and convenience. As a result many businesses invested heavily in platforms to stay competitive in retail.

Consumer preference is key to e-commerce success. Online retailers must understand how consumers make purchasing decisions and what factors influence their choices. When shopping online many factors affect consumer choices. Convenience is crucial as online platforms allow shopping anytime and anywhere. Pricing is also significant as consumers compare prices before buying. Trust and security are vital for online transactions.

Technological advancements have strengthened e-commerce platforms influence on consumer preferences. Modern platforms use intelligence, data analytics and recommendation systems for personalized product suggestions based on consumers browsing and purchasing history on e-commerce platforms. Consumers are increasingly dependent on e-commerce platforms for their purchasing needs because of the convenience and easy availability of products on e-commerce platforms. E-commerce businesses must prioritize consumer preferences to achieve success and sustainability in e-commerce. Online retailers need to understand consumer behavior, on e-commerce platforms.

LITERATURE REVIEW

Consumer Behavior in E-commerce:

When people shop online they do things a little differently. They look at things like product descriptions and reviews to decide what to buy. Online shopping is not like going to a store where you can touch things. You have to rely on what you see on the computer. This makes a difference in how people make up their minds. Liang Chen and Dan He said that people like to shop on websites that're easy to use. If a website is hard to use people might not want to buy things from it.

People also worry about things when they shop online. They cannot see the product in person so they might worry that it is not what they want. People might also worry that their payment information is not safe when they shop online.

Factors Influencing Consumer Preferences:

There are things that affect what people like when they shop on the internet. If online stores know what people like they can make their online stores better. People will want to shop at these stores again. Some of these things are:

Convenience: Online shopping is easy. People like that because they can shop from home or from else. They do not have to go to a store. That saves them time. This is really good for people who're busy. Online stores also have things that make shopping easier. They have search tools and simple checkout.

Discounts: People like it when things are cheap. Online stores often have prices than regular stores. They also have sales and special offers. People like that. Online stores do not have to pay for things like rent. So they can charge money for things. They can also give people discounts, like coupon codes. That makes people happy when they shop at stores.

Jothimani et al. (2023) note that the transparency of online pricing allows consumers to compare prices across multiple platforms easily, increasing their sensitivity to prices differences.

Website Quality and usability:

Website quality and usability also significantly influence consumer preferences. A well-designed website with clear navigation, fast loading speed, and detailed product information improves the shopping experience and encourages consumers to complete purchases. According to William H.

Delone and Ephraim McLean did a study in 2003. They found that the quality of a system and the accuracy of the information it provides are important. These things decide if users are happy with platforms and if they keep using them.

Delivery Services: Delivery services help make customers happy with shopping. Things like delivery speed, shipping costs and on-time arrival make customers think the service is good or not. When a company has a delivery system and keeps customers updated on their order they trust the company more. They are more likely to shop again.

The purpose of this study is to see what people like about online shopping on e-commerce platforms. It is about finding out what makes people happy, with shopping. The study looks at e-commerce platforms. It wants

to know what people like about them. The goal is to understand what makes online shopping good or bad. This will help companies improve their services.

What makes them buy things on the internet? More and more people are using the internet and digital technology is getting better so people are choosing to shop of going to stores.

This study looks at things like how easy it's to shop how good the products are, the price, discounts and special offers what other customers say, how easy it is to pay how fast things are delivered and what happens if you want to return something. This study finds out which e-commerce platforms people like the most and how happy they're with shopping online. The results of this study will help e-commerce companies make their customer service better come up with marketing plans and make people happier and more loyal to their e-commerce brand.

HYPOTHESES OF THE STUDY

Hypothesis 1

H01: There is no relationship between discounts and promotional offers and consumer purchasing decisions on e-commerce platforms.

H11: There is a relationship between discounts and promotional offers and consumer purchasing decisions on e-commerce platforms.

Hypothesis 2

H02: There is no relationship between customer reviews and rating and consumer preference toward e-commerce platforms.

H12: There is a relationship between customer reviews and ratings and consumer preference toward e-commerce platforms.

RESEARCH METHODOLOGY

Research Design

This study looks at what people like about shopping on e-commerce platforms. It uses two types of research methods: one to describe things and another to analyze them.

The descriptive method presents information about how people shop on e-commerce platforms how often they do it which e-commerce shopping platforms they prefer, how they like to pay for things on e-commerce

platforms and how satisfied they are with e-commerce services. Tables, graphs and percentages are used to help show this information about e-commerce platforms.

The analytical method tries to figure out how different things affect peoples decisions to buy online from e-commerce platforms. It checks if things like discounts on e-commerce platforms what other customers say about e-commerce platforms, delivery services from e-commerce platforms and how happy customers are with e-commerce platforms are connected.

The study uses techniques like the test and correlation analysis to see if these things are related to e-commerce platforms. Using both methods helps get results and meaningful insights from the data collected about e-commerce platforms.

The study examines consumer preferences towards e-commerce platforms. Consumer preferences towards e-commerce platforms are studied using these methods. The results come from analyzing data about consumer behavior on e-commerce platforms e-commerce platforms and online shopping on e-commerce platforms.

SOURCES OF DATA

The research is based on both data.

Primary Data

Primary data for this study was collected from the people who took part in the study on e-commerce platforms. We used a questionnaire made with Google forms to help us gather the data about e-commerce platforms.

The questionnaire had questions with answers that covered things like what consumers prefer on e-commerce platforms. It also looked at how people shop on e-commerce platforms, which e-commerce platforms they like what payment options they use on e-commerce platforms and how happy they are with e-commerce services, on e-commerce platforms.

We got the data directly from respondents using this questionnaire.

Secondary Data

I got the information for this project from a lot of places. I looked at research papers, books and articles. I also checked out company reports, websites and online databases. I even read studies about online shopping and how people buy things on the internet. These things helped me understand what people like when they shop online and how they do it. The information also showed me that online shopping is getting really popular. I learned about the basics of online shopping and how people behave when they buy things on the internet.

These sources gave me a lot of information, about what people like and what they do not like when they shop online. The sources also talked about how fast online shopping's growing. Online shopping is a part of commerce now.

Sample Design

The study used the convenience sampling techniques to choose respondents according to their availability and readiness to take part in the survey. A total 120 participants from urban cities including Bhopal, Raipur, Bilaspur, and Durg were included in the research. The respondents included students, salaried employees, business owners, homemakers, and other consumers who regularly shop through e-commerce platforms. The selected sample helped in studying consumer preferences, buying behavior, satisfaction levels, and the factor affecting online purchasing decisions.

RESEARCH INSTRUMENTS

The main research instrument used for this study was a structured questionnaire designed using Google forms. The questionnaire included multiple-choice and close-ended questions to gather information related to:

- Consumer preferences towards e-commerce platforms
- Frequency of online shopping
- Preferred payment options
- Types of products purchased online
- Influence of customer reviews on buying decisions
- Satisfaction with delivery services
- Experience regarding return and refund policies

The questionnaire method was chosen because it is an easy, cost-effective and efficient way to collect data from a large number of respondents.

VARIABLES OF THE STUDY

Independent Variable:

The study looks at discounts, product quality, customer reviews, delivery services, payment options and return policies as factors.

These things are really important, to people when they are shopping on e-commerce sites and deciding what to buy.

People care about these things when they are buying things on the internet and they look at discounts and product quality and customer reviews and delivery services and payment options and return policies.

Dependent Variable:

The main thing this study is focused on is what people like and how happy they are with shopping sites.

This is influenced by things that affect how people buy things online and their overall experience with e-commerce sites.

Control Variable:

The study also looks at age, gender, job, income and education level as control variables.

By keeping these things constant the analysis of what people prefer and how they shop online becomes more accurate and effective.

The study considers age, gender, occupation, income level and educational qualification to understand their impact, on e-commerce sites and online shopping behavior.

These control variables help to make the analysis of consumer preferences and online shopping behavior more accurate.

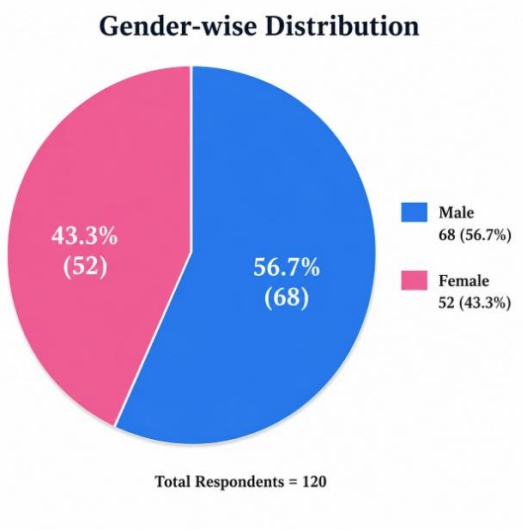
DATA ANALYSIS AND INTERPRETATIONS

This part of the study is about looking at the information we got from people and what it means. We did a study called "Consumer Preference Analysis in E-commerce platforms." We asked people questions using Google forms. We got answers from 120 people from different groups. We looked at what they said and used numbers and pictures to help us understand it better. We also tried to figure out what people think and feel. The main thing we wanted to do in this part of the study is to see what people like when they shop online how often they do it what they usually buy and what makes them decide to buy something from an e-commerce platform. We looked at things like which e-commerce platforms people like best how often they shop online what kinds of things they buy how they pay, if customer reviews matter to them what they think of delivery services and if they are happy, with their experience. We want to know about consumer preferences, online shopping patterns, satisfaction levels and what influences people to buy things from e-commerce platforms.

Table1. Gender wise analysis

Gender	Number of respondents	Percentage

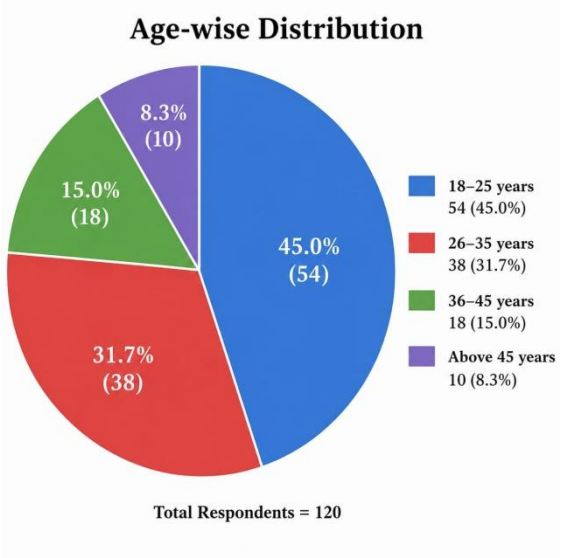
Male	68	56.7%
Female	52	43.3%
Total	120	100%



Interpretation – Out of the total 120 respondents, 68 were male, making up 56.7% of the sample, whereas 52 were female, representing 43.3%. the result show that male participants were slightly more than female participants in the study. This indicates that both men and women are engaged in using e-commerce platforms, but malt consumers showed a somewhat higher level of participants in this research.

Table2. Age-wise analysis:

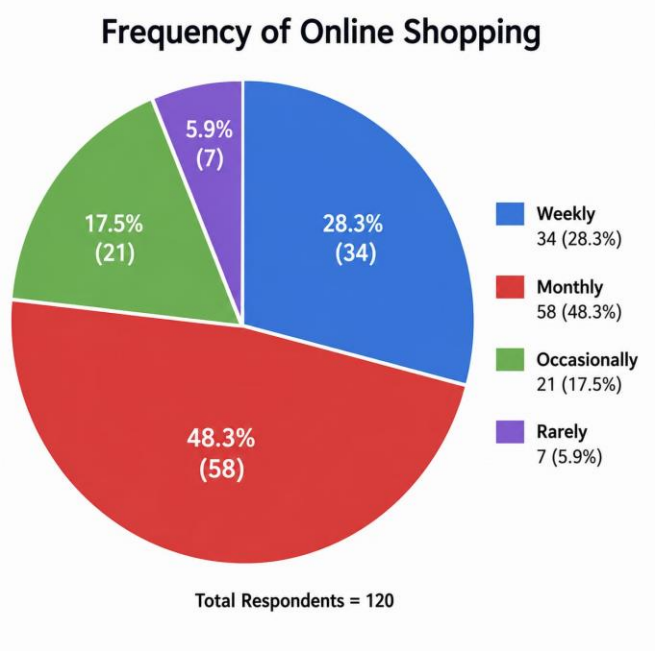
Age group	Respondents	Percentage
18-25 years	54	45%
26-35 years	38	31.7%
36-45 years	18	15%
Above 45 years	10	8.3%
Total	120	100%



Interpretation – The table above shows the distribution of respondents according to age. Most of the participants fall under the 18-25 years age category, making up 45% of the total sample, followed by 26-35 years with 31.7%. The 36-45 years age group accounts for 15% while those above 45 years represent only8.3%. The findings reveal that younger individuals are more involved in online shopping and tend to use e-commerce platforms more regularly for buying goods and services.

Table3. Frequency of online shopping:

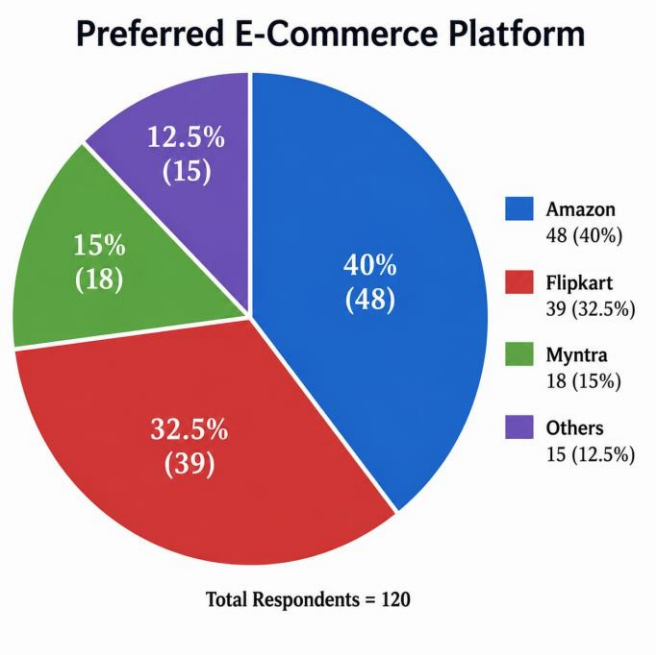
Frequency	Number of respondents	Percentage
Weekly	34	28.3%
Monthly	58	48.3%
Occasionally	21	17.5%
Rarely	7	5.9%
Total	120	100%



Interpretation – The table above illustrates how often respondents engage in online shopping. People like to shop about once a month. This is what most people do half of them. Then there are people who shop online every week this is a quarter of them. Some people buy things online every now and then this is seventeen and a half percent of people. A small number of people six percent do not shop online very often. Online shopping is something a lot of people do. They do it because it is easy. They like that they can buy all sorts of things from home and they like that there are always deals to be found. People also like that they can get to all the things they want to buy without having to go out. Online shopping is something that people do it is a normal thing for many people to do.

Table4. Preferred e-commerce platforms:

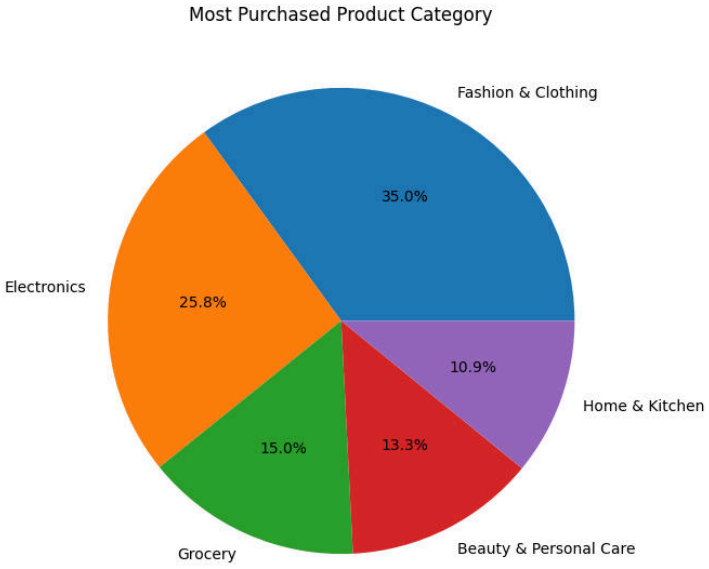
Platforms	Respondents	Percentage
Amazon	48	40%
Flipkart	39	32.5%
Myntra	18	15%
Others	15	12.5%
Total	120	100%



Interpretation – The table above shows the preferred e-commerce platforms among the respondents. Amazon was the most chosen platform with 40% of respondents, followed by flipkart at 32.5%. Myntra was selected by 15% of the participants, while the remaining 12.5% used other platforms. The results suggest that consumer mainly favor amazon and flipkart due to their wide product range, attractive discounts, dependable delivery services, and overall smooth shopping experience.

Table5. Most purchased product category:

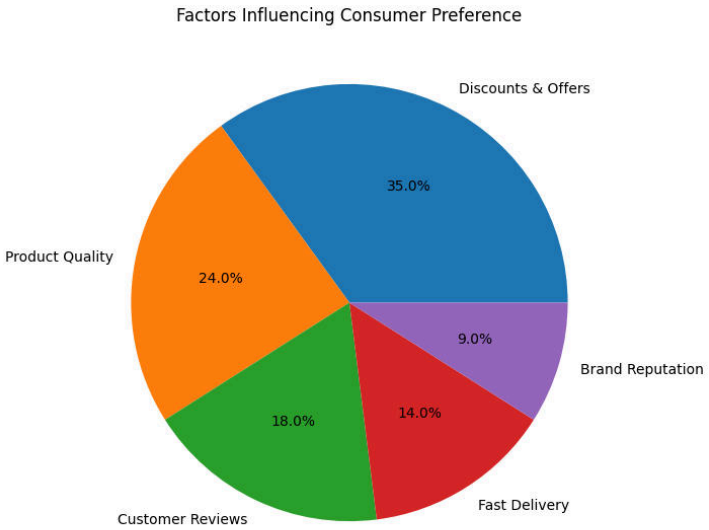
Product category	Respondents	Percentage
Fashion & clothing	42	35%
Electronic	31	25.8%
Grocery	18	15%
Beauty & personal care	16	13.3%
Home & kitchen	13	10.9%
Total	120	100%



Interpretation – The table above highlights the most commonly purchased product categories via e-commerce platforms. Fashion and clothing emerged as the leading category with 35% of respondents, followed by electronics at 25.8%. Grocery items accounted for 15%, while beauty and personal care products made up 13.3%. Home and kitchen products were purchased by 10.9% of the respondents. The results shows that consumers primarily choose online shopping for fashion and electronic goods because of the wide range of options, convenience and attractive discounts offered online.

Table6. Factors influencing consumer preference:

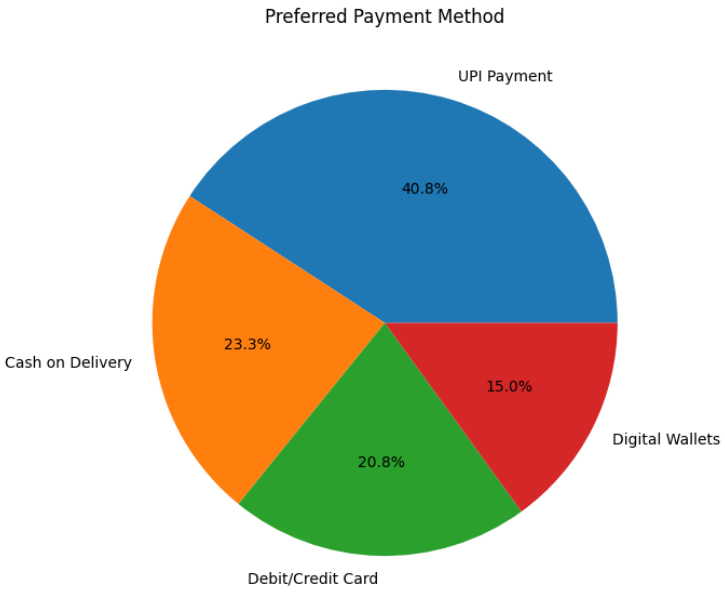
Factors	Percentage
Discounts & offers	35%
Product quality	24%
Customer reviews	18%
Fast delivery	14%
Brand reputation	9%
Total	100%



Interpretation – The graph shows that discounts and promotional offers play the most important role in shaping consumer preferences on e-commerce platforms, representing 35% of response. Shoppers are strongly drawn toward price cuts and special deals available online. Product quality comes next with 24%, indicating that customers also prioritize reliable and long-lasting products. Customer reviews account for 18%, as they help build trust and guide purchase decisions. Fast delivery services (14%) and brand reputation (9%) have a relatively lesser impact, but they still contribute to overall customer satisfaction.

Table7. Preferred payment methods:

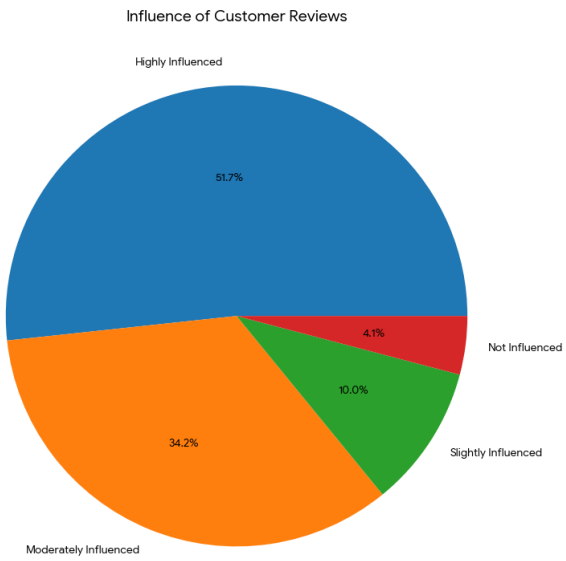
Payment methods	Respondents	Percentage
UPI payment	49	40.8%
Cash on delivery	28	23.3%
Debit/credit card	25	20.8%
Digital wallets	18	15%
Total	120	100%



Interpretation – The graph shows that UPI is the most commonly used payment method among consumers, preferred by 40.8% of respondents because it is quick, easy, and convenient. Cash on delivery is used by 23.3% of consumers, showing that many still prefer paying after receiving the product. Debit and credit card are used by 20.8% of respondents, while digital wallets are chosen by 15%. Overall, the findings indicate that digital payment methods are becoming more popular in e-commerce platforms.

Table8. Influence of customer reviews

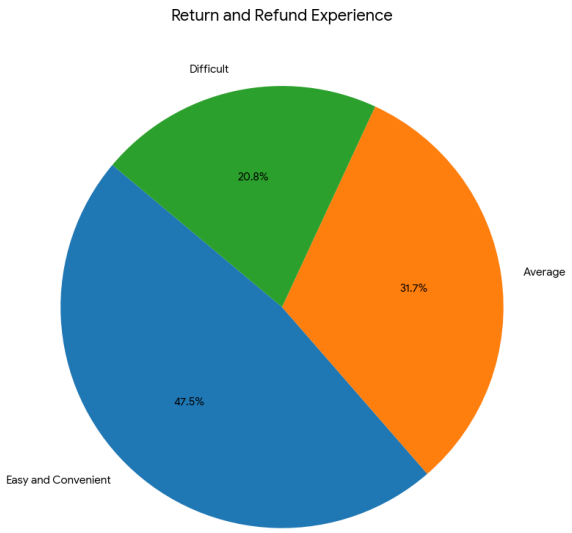
Response	Respondents	Percentage
Highly influenced	62	51.7%
Moderately influenced	41	34.2%
Slightly influenced	12	10%
Not influenced	5	4.1%
Total	120	100%



Interpretation – The data shows that customer reviews play a major role in influencing buying decision on e-commerce platforms. Most respondents (51.7%) are strongly influenced by reviews, which mean they depend a lot on ratings and feedback before purchasing a product. Another 34.2% are moderately influenced, while 10% are slightly influenced. Only a few groups of 4.1% are not affected by reviews. Overall, the results show that online reviews are very important in building trust, reducing uncertainty, and helping consumers make better purchase decisions.

Table9. Return and Refund experience

Opinion	Respondents	Percentage
Easy and convenient	57	47.5%
Average	38	31.7%
Difficult	25	20.8%
Total	120	100



Interpretation – Almost half of the respondents (47.5%) said that returning and getting refund is easy, which shows a good experience with e-commerce sites. Around 31.7% feel it is okay but not very good, so they are partly satisfied. However 20.8% of people said it is difficult, mostly because of delays, confusion, or complicated steps. Overall, most users are happy, but making the return and refund process simpler can improve customer satisfaction even more.

TOOLS USED FOR ANALYSIS

Chi-Square Test

Meaning

The Chi-Square Test is a statistical tool used to check whether two things are connected or not. In this study, it is used to see whether customer reviews affect what people decide to buy on e-commerce websites. It helps understand whether factors like reviews, payment options, return experience, and platform choice are linked with buying behavior.

Objective

The main goal is to find out if customer reviews play an important role in influencing online purchasing decisions.

Observed Values

Response	Observed Frequency (O)
Highly Influenced	62
Moderately Influenced	41
Slightly Influenced	12
Not Influenced	5
Total	120

Expected Value Formula

The expected frequency is calculated using:

E = (Row Total) (Column Total)/Grand Total

Since only one variable distribution is available, equal distribution assumption is used.

Expected Values Calculation

Total Respondents = 120

Number of Categories = 4

Expected Value for each category:

E= 120/4= 30

So:

Response	Observed (O)	Expected (E)
Highly Influenced	62	30
Moderately Influenced	41	30
Slightly Influenced	12	30
Not Influenced	5	30

Chi-Square Formula

$\chi 2 = \sum (O-E)^2 / E$

Chi-Square Calculation Table

Response	O	E	O-E	$(O-E)^2$	$(O-E)^2/E$
Highly Influenced	62	30	32	1024	34.13
Moderately Influenced	41	30	11	121	4.03
Slightly Influenced	12	30	-18	324	10.80
Not Influenced	5	30	-25	625	20.83

Total Chi-Square Value

$\chi 2 = 34.13 + 4.03 + 10.80 + 20.83 = 69.79$

Degree of Freedom

Formula:

$df = (n-1)$

Where:

n = number of categories = 4

So,

$df = 4-1 = 3$

Critical Value

At:

Significance level = 0.05

Degree of freedom = 3

Critical Value = 7.815

Decision

Calculated Value	Critical Value
69.79	7.815

Since:

69.79>7.815

Correlation Analysis

Meaning

Correlation analysis is a statistical method used to understand how strongly two variables are related and in what direction they move. In this study, it helps examine relationships such as customer reviews and purchase decisions, website quality and customer satisfaction, and delivery services and customer loyalty.

Objective

The main objective is to study the relationship between customer reviews and consumers' purchasing preferences.

Correlation Formula (Karl Pearson's Correlation)

$r = n \sum XY - (\sum X)(\sum Y) / \sqrt{[n\sum X^2 - (\sum X)^2][n\sum Y^2 - (\sum Y)^2]}$

Calculation

Response	X Value	Y Value
Highly Influenced	4	62

Moderately Influenced	3	41
Slightly Influenced	2	12
Not Influenced	1	5

Required Table for Correlation

X	Y	XY	X^2	Y^2
4	62	248	16	3844
3	41	123	9	1681
2	12	24	4	144
1	5	5	1	25

Totals:

ΣX	ΣY	ΣXY	ΣX^2	ΣY^2
10	120	400	30	5694

n = 4

Correlation Calculation

Substituting values into formula:

$r = 4(400) - (10)(120) / \sqrt{[4(30) - 10^2][4(5694) - 120^2]}$

$r = 1600 - 1200 / \sqrt{(120-100)(22776-14400)}$

$r = 400 / \sqrt{20 \times 8376}$

$r = 400/409.29 = 0.97$

Interpretation of Correlation Result

Correlation Value	Interpretation
r = 0.97	Very High Positive Correlation

Conclusion

There is a very strong positive relationship between customer reviews and consumer preference. When people say things about a product more people want to buy it.

FUTURE SCOPE

This study about what people like to buy on the internet helps us understand how people shop online and what makes them buy things. Technology and what people want are always changing, so there is a lot more to learn about this. As more people start shopping on the internet over the world we need to study what people want and what is new in technology to understand why people shop online.

We can do studies with people from different places to get a better idea of what people like. This study only asked a group of people but we can ask people from different cities and countries to get more information. It would be good to compare how people from cities and towns shop on the internet to see if they have ideas about shopping online.

We can also study how old people are, if they are men or women what they do for work and how money they make to see what they like to buy on the internet. Different people like things so businesses can use this information to sell things to people in a better way.

Another thing we can study is how new technology like intelligence and virtual reality is changing the way people shop on the internet. More and more people are using these technologies to shop so we need to see how they work.

We can also look at how social media's changing the way people shop. Social media is a way for companies to tell people about their products so we need to study how it works.

People are still worried about shopping on the internet because they do not want their information to be stolen. So we need to study how to keep people safe when they shop on the internet.

CONCLUSION

Understanding what people like to buy helps us see why people like to shop on the internet much. People like to shop on the internet because they can find what they want and buy it easily.

Consumer preference is important to understand because it helps us see how people shop online and why consumer preference is important, for e-commerce platforms. E-commerce platforms are becoming more popular because they make it easy for people to buy what they want.

It shows that several different factors shape customers' buying choices. Online shopping is really popular because it is easy to use. People can buy things whenever they want. From wherever they are which saves them time and effort. They do not have to go to stores. This way of shopping is simple and people like that they can do it whenever they want so they come back to online shopping again.

Online shopping is also good because of the prices. Most people, like it when they can get a deal. They like discounts and low prices. When online stores have deals and sales people feel like they are getting a good price so they are more likely to buy something.

People also like online shopping because they feel safe. They like it when they can pay for things safely and when they can return things easily. They also like it when they can get help if they need it. Online shopping makes people feel safe and confident so they are happy and they come back to shop again.

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